Awami League's Sheikh Hasina was in power), which directed 'their respective [security] agencies to ensure that development work, including construction of integrated check posts, is allowed within 150 yards of the zero line, on the basis of prior intimation from the other side'.

Since then, Hasina has been ousted from power and it is unclear whether Rahman and his BNP will uphold the 2017 understanding. Meanwhile, uncertainty looms in Bengal over the 2.7 million people who have lost their voting rights under the special intensive revision (SIR) process of the electoral rolls. Reports suggest that by mid-May, 12 of the 19 Supreme Court-mandated Appellate Tribunals had disposed of only 6,581 of the 2.49 million appeals filed.

DISTRESS AND DIPLOMACY

Many among those excluded are Indian citizens who failed to make it to the voter list because of administrative lapses and documentation-related issues. These people fear the revised SIR list could eventually become the baseline for determining citizenship status, and that those whose names do not appear on it may face serious consequences.

Amid these developments, India-Bangladesh relations, which had hit rock bottom following Hasina's ouster in 2024, face further strain. Former foreign secretary Harsh Vardhan Shringla, now a Rajya Sabha MP from the BJP, feels that cooperation on sensitive matters is the only way forward. "There is direct correlation between Bengal and Bangladesh on administrative issues. Fencing the borders and putting an end to illegal immigration will help both nations. Our neighbours should cooperate with us," he says. Across the border, ex-Bangladeshi diplomat M. Humayun Kabir points to India's domestic rhetoric as a possible hurdle. "It so happens that certain statements made by Indian politicians have triggered reactions in our country. Neither is welcome," he says.

What began as a drive against illegals is fast turning into a larger political and diplomatic test for both India and Bangladesh. As West Bengal's new BJP government sharpens its stand, ties between the two neighbours will be tested. ■

▶ MADHYA PRADESH

NOMINATION SHOCK

How Meenakshi Natarajan lost a Rajya Sabha seat the Congress thought secure

By **Rahul Noronha**

THE CANCELLATION OF MEENAKSHI NATARAJAN'S Rajya Sabha nomination in Madhya Pradesh says more about the Congress than the BJP. It exposes the party's chronic infighting, poor preparedness and refusal to learn from past mistakes. The BJP did what any party with an aggressive election machinery does. It found, or, as the Congress alleges, 'invented' a weakness in the opposition candidate's papers, raised an objection and converted a contest into an unopposed win.

The math had looked straightforward. In the 230-member MP assembly, each RS candidate needed 58 first-preference votes. With 164 MLAs, the BJP could win two seats; with 62, the Congress could win one (two MLAs have cases in court and couldn't vote). But the BJP fielded a third candidate, Mahesh



RAJEEV GUPTA